



Smith & Wesson Model 52

The **Smith & Wesson Model 52**, sometimes referred to as the **38 Master**, is a semi-automatic pistol developed by Smith & Wesson for Bullseye shooting. It was one of the first semiautomatic pistols chambered in .38 Special with flush-seated, full wadcutter bullets. The shape of the rimmed cartridge limited the magazine capacity to five rounds. A variant, known as the Model 952, in 9 mm Parabellum, is still produced in limited quantities by Smith & Wesson's Performance Center. The Model 52 was discontinued in 1993 when the machinery to manufacture the pistol broke down and it was deemed too costly to replace.^[1]

History

In 1961, Smith & Wesson Model introduced the Model 52 as a match-grade target pistol derived from the Smith & Wesson Model 39. It was chambered in .38 Special Wadcutter for the sport of Bullseye shooting.^[2]

The first version, known simply as the Model 52, retained the basic trigger mechanism of the Model 39, with the Double-Action function selectable via a simple frame-mounted setscrew, allowing the pistol to be fired in either single-action or double-action mode depending on the setscrew's adjustment.^[2]

In 1963, the Model 52-1 was introduced with a separately developed single-action trigger system and was manufactured until 1970, when it was succeeded by the Model 52-2. Changes to the 52-2 included an improved extractor and this version was manufactured for 23 years.^[2]

By 1992, the 30-year-old machinery used to make the Model 52 was showing signs of age and was starting to fail. Smith & Wesson decided against replacing it and the handgun was discontinued. The last model 52-2 was completed on July 23, 1993. The pistol's serial number was “TZW9149” and it was delivered to the company's private gun vault as an archive piece.^{[2][3]}

Smith & Wesson Model 52



S&W M52-2 with barrel weight

Type	Semi-automatic pistol
Place of origin	United States
Production history	
Produced	1961–1993 (Model 52) 2000–2012 (Model 952)
Specifications	
Mass	40 oz (1,100 g)
Length	8.55 in (217 mm)
Barrel length	5 in (130 mm)
Cartridge	<u>.38 Special</u> (Model 52) <u>9×19 mm Parabellum</u> (Model 952)
Action	<u>Short recoil</u> , <u>SA</u>
Rate of fire	<u>Semi-automatic</u>
Feed system	<u>5-round single column</u> , detachable <u>box magazine</u>

Model 952

The Smith & Wesson Model 952 was introduced in 2000 as a Performance Center pistol based on the Model 52 but chambered in 9mm. Enhancements included a 5" match-grade barrel, titanium-coated spherical barrel bushing, 9-round magazine, loaded chamber indicator and a slide-mounted decocking lever.^[4] An enhanced version was produced in 2004 and a long slide variant with a 6" barrel debuted in 2006.^[5] Smith & Wesson would later on discontinue the Model 952 in 2012.^[6]

References

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